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« As soon as you're an Olympic winner, the power of your voice starts to rise and you can achieve so much more »

THOMAS ROHLER

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Two Olympic champions will be on the field at the Neeraj Chopra Classic event in Bengaluru on July 5. One, of course, is Neeraj himself. The other is Thomas Rohler who won gold at the 2016 Games in Rio.

Rohler was one of the men to beat during the 2016–2020 Olympic cycle — his 93.90m throw at the 2017 Doha Diamond League placed him third on the all-time list for the javelin throw. He would likely have been among the favourites to defend his Olympic crown in Tokyo, but a serious back injury put an end to his hopes, paving the way for Neeraj to enter the history books.

Since then, Rohler's comeback has been slow. He has struggled to recapture the form that once made him a world-beater and eventually missed out on the 2024 Olympics as

well. However, the 32-year-old isn't done with the sport just yet.

In this interview with *Sportstar*, Rohler opens up about making peace with his injuries, what keeps him motivated, and what goals remain for an athlete like him who has already won nearly everything there is to win.

He also reflects on Neeraj's role in growing the sport and the recent burst of talent in India in a discipline that was once dominated by European athletes.

Why did you decide to come to India?

Competing in India was on my bucket list. I mean, it's the fastest-growing javelin community in the world right now, and it's just logical to have an international meet here. Getting the invite directly from the Indian Olympic champion was an honour. I was happy to hear that he's super involved. I know from my own experience that conducting a meet is

an extra bit of work for an athlete. I'm glad he is putting in the work to help the javelin community, and I'm happy to come and help him as well.

Neeraj was a big fan of yours back in 2016 when he was still starting out. What is it like to now compete at a tournament alongside him?

We have interacted and competed before and are genuinely respectful to each other. I also think we share the same Olympic values. This is how sport works — you start competing with your role models. I know it from my own experience. When I first started competing with javelin throwers like Norwegian Andreas Thorkildsen or Tero Pitkamaki from Finland, that was a huge moment for me. So I can feel how he must have felt competing for the first time against — or with — me. This is just how sport evolves: the young ones eventually start to beat you. And it's a good thing.